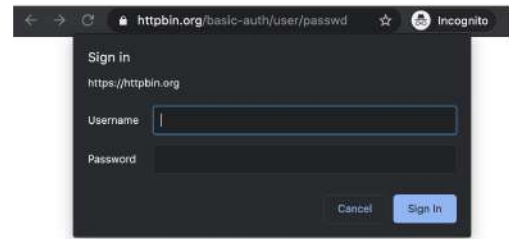


Mechanism to authenticate access to resources over HTTP

Credentials are sent in the request headers

Authorization: Basic aGltOm92ZXJhY2hpZXZlcg==

Base64 encoded username and password



How does it work?

Ever seen this page?

This is basic authentication in play

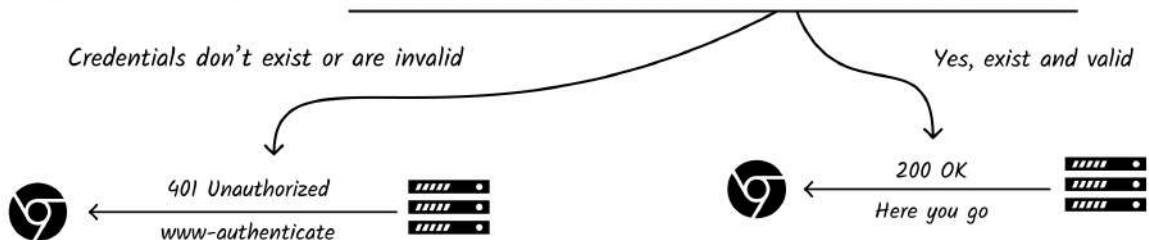
Step 1

Client tries to access some protected URL



Step 2

Server checks if the request has **Authorization** header with valid username and password?



```
HTTP/1.1 401 Unauthorized
Date: Sat, 16 May 2020 16:50:53 GMT
WWW-Authenticate: Basic realm="MyApp"
```

Response to the client

realm or protection space

Group of pages where the same credentials are used. Browser can cache the valid credentials for given realm and use them in future

Step 3

Browser notices the **www-authenticate** header in response and presents the alert for credentials.

(Similar to the one shown on the top right)

Freeform text. Can be anything. Server is responsible for defining realms and do the authentication.

Step 4

User submits the credentials. Browser encodes them using base64 and sends in the next request. Credentials are sent in the **Authorization** header in request as follows

Authorization: Basic aGltOm92Y2hpZXZlcg==

base64("username:password")

Step 5 Go to step 2 i.e. server does the authentication and cycle continues.

Basic auth can also be used in APIs but in that case it's just like normal token based authentication

Note

Basic auth is not considered secure unless used with TLS/HTTPS.

Because anyone can eavesdrop and decode the credentials